The Best Medicine

By Joshua Sands

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *When Kristen learned she had cancer, she was desperate for the friendship and advice of patients her age. Young adults with cancer slip into a lonely no-man's land. Too old for the instant community of a children's hospital, they still don't fit in with the over-50 community that overwhelmingly populates adult cancer wards.*

ACTRESS: *I figured there was nobody else out there. I was so isolated, I didn't even realize how lonely I was.*

TOGETHER: *Welcome to Planet Cancer.*

ACTRESS: *No, we didn't choose to come here. But we ended up as honorary natives of this terrible and wonderful world. Like other planets, Planet Cancer rotates regularly between the dark side of night and the brightness of day.*

ACTOR: *All too often, we lose ourselves on the dark side, forgetting that where there is night, day must follow; and where there is life, there is the light of hope and laughter.*

TOGETHER: *The Best Medicine by Joshua Sands*

RYAN: **(Pg 51-54)** You'd think they'd find a new way to give us this spiel.

KRISTEN: Quiet – I'm trying to hear.

RYAN: Basically I think what he is trying to tell us is that we all have cancer –

KRISTEN: Shoosh!

RYAN: So you're a shoosher. Don't worry. This diatribe ends the meeting. I'm surprised they don't break out into a chorus of "I Will Survive!"

KRISTEN: Shoosh!

RYAN: You know, your lips are kinda sexy when you—

KRISTEN: Look, I know you're just trying to make a friend, but I need these meetings. Don't you?

RYAN: Sure. But, I need to talk to humans sometimes, too.

KRISTEN: Yeah, I guess this disease can be kinda lonely.

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RYAN: You understate yourself. I think I'm gonna like you. . . So, what's your name?

KRISTEN: Kristen.

RYAN: I'm surprised you didn't say "Cancer Victim #3647B."

KRISTEN: What's yours?

RYAN: Ryan. Sorry if I'm too sarcastic tonight. Whenever Mark runs the meetings –

KRISTEN: You come here a lot.

RYAN: A couple times a week. You?

KRISTEN: Just starting. I'm not so sure if I like it.

RYAN: Listen, why don't we go out and do something fun?

KRISTEN: I don't know.

RYAN: Two dates. That's all I ask.

KRISTEN: Two? Most guys settle for just one.

RYAN: Yeah, but I like variety. You can't tell anything in one date. Say we go ice-skating. Should that be the only test if we're compatible?

KRISTEN: I don't know.

RYAN: Two dates. One goofy, high-schoolish date. One romantic date. If you hate them both you can go back to sitting at these meetings in peace and quiet. (a beat). So? Don't tell me your dance card is already full?

KRISTEN: No. I'll try it. Be spontaneous, right? What can it hurt?

*******Scene break*******

RYAN: You missed!

KRISTEN: When you said goofy and high-schoolish, I had no clue we'd end up at the fair. but, it fits the category.

RYAN: Now follow through with the arm. You can knock em' all over if you have the right precision and force.

KRISTEN: You sound like an expert . . .

RYAN: Sure. Did this a lot when I was goofy and high-schoolish.

KRISTEN: *(laughs)* I was too busy going to cheerleading camp. And tennis camp. And—

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RYAN: *(laughs)* Oh, an overachiever. Well, listen. We're just cancer victims now. No more strenuous effort to try and make our future brighter. Just focus on today. This softball. Those bottles.

KRISTEN: That's all?

RYAN: Yeah, focus on what you can control. Your mind. Your heart. Your way of getting through the day with a chuckle or two. It helps.

KRISTEN: You learn that from Mark?

RYAN: Hell, no. I learned that the hard way. Practice.

KRISTEN: Hey, nice throw.

*******Scene Break*******

RYAN: Hi, Kristen? It's Ryan. Just wanted to make plans for date #2

KRISTEN: You were serious about this pair of dates thing?

RYAN: Yeah, were you?

KRISTEN: Sure. What did you have in mind?

RYAN: Romance. That's what I promised, right? Wear a cocktail dress and I'll pick you up at 7:00. No wait -- gotta stop and talk to the witch doctor about the cancerous Pacman eating my liver.

KRISTEN: What?

RYAN: Pick you up at 7:30. Bye.

*******Scene Break*******

KRISTEN: So. . . a boat. . . champagne. . . dancing . . .

RYAN: Might think I'm trying to show off, huh?

KRISTEN: I might think that.

RYAN: You enjoying yourself?

KRISTEN: Yeah, it amazes me how I forget everything with you. Do you even think about dying?

RYAN: Dying? Why? When I can be dancing with you?

KRISTEN: Really, do you?

RYAN: You know the champagne is great – *(loses balance, almost falls)*

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KRISTEN: You OK?

RYAN: Yeah, must be the champagne. Maybe it's the ocean. I'm fine.

KRISTEN: Let's take a breather.

RYAN: Well . . . *(sigh)* okay deal.

*******Scene Break*******

RYAN: See, now this is the part when Mark asks for prayer requests.

KRISTEN: Very nice Nostradamus.

RYAN: Then one by one, everyone eventually stands up and says "Yea, umm, You see I've got this cancer thing…"

KRISTEN: Ryan, I don't think I'm coming to the meetings anymore.

RYAN: What? You have to.

KRISTEN: Why? You don't like them and I'd rather be with Ryan my boyfriend rather than Ryan the cancer meeting smart-alick.

RYAN: So you don't like my jokes?

KRISTEN: No—I just want to separate this from our relationship.

RYAN: Kris, it's not a good idea. Promise you'll come on Friday?

KRISTEN: Fine. Promise.

*******Scene Break*******

KRISTEN: *(on answering machine)* Ryan? Hi. It's Kristen. I showed up last night. It was the one at St. Andrew's, right? Where were you? Give me a call, OK? Bye.

*******Scene Break*******

RYAN: It was nothing!

KRISTEN: Ryan, you had me so worried!

RYAN: I just got a little queasy at work and fell asleep. They thought I had passed out!

KRISTEN: Ryan, you spent the whole weekend in the hospital.

RYAN: I know. But don't worry. Cancer is like this great ballgame. I haven't struck out. This weekend is like the seventh inning stretch.

KRISTEN: Are you sure you're alright?

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RYAN: Fine. Got a green tongue. Wanna see?

KRISTEN: Ryan, really. It's time to stop the jokes.

RYAN: I know. I missed the meeting. I'll pull a double on Tuesday.

KRISTEN: Ryan—

RYAN: Kristen, let's go out on another pair of dates. Let's see—how about snowboarding and a show this time?

KRISTEN: Damn it, Ryan! Talk to me! Don't give me one-liners. Don't try out for a cancer comedy troupe. Talk to me! We're dying here! We have a couple months to fit everything in, and you're wasting it with all this bullshit!

RYAN: Is that what you think? This is all bulls***. The fair? The dancing? The lunches at the bistro? If that's bull***, what the hell is the real stuff? What's real, Kris?

KRISTEN: I don't know . . .

RYAN: I'll tell you what's real. You and me. Spending time together. Laughing together. Playing Monopoly. Watching Conan on TV. That's what's real. That's what's real Kris.

KRISTEN: *(pause)* But your cancer is real, too.

RYAN: Yeah, and it'll consume you if you let it. Don't. Don't let it consume you. Please don't.

*******Scene Break*******

KRISTEN: Hi, my name is Kristen. I've got colon cancer. God, I don't know how to do this. See—I met my boyfriend in here. Now it's just me. And I don't know how to do this on my own. He always helped me laugh, but now—

RYAN: No more strenuous effort to try and make our future brighter. Just focus on today.

KRISTEN: I mean, I hear him speaking to me.

RYAN: Focus on what you can control. Your mind. Your heart. Your way of getting through the day with a chuckle or two. It helps.

KRISTEN: And he makes sense. But it's so hard to keep the words living when he's gone. All I can think of saying here are jokes about how this'll make our tongue green. But see, you're not laughing. Guess you had to be there.

RYAN: I'll tell you what's real. You and me. Kristen, you and me.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Joshua Sands
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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier

NCFL National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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